I said that children in Lesotho were in trouble, and I loved children, understood children, so naturally I wanted to help.

He pressed. Why did I love children?

I gave my best guess: My incredible immaturity?

I was being glib, but the reporter chuckled and moved on to his next question. The subject of children had opened the door to the subject of my childhood, and that was the gateway to the only subject he, or anyone, really wanted to ask me about.

Do you think about…her…a lot through something like this?

I looked off, down the hillside, responded with a series of disjointed words: *Unfortunately it's been a long time now, um, not for me but for most people, it's been a long time since she's died, but the stuff that's come out has been bad, all the stuff that's come out, all these tapes…*

I was referring to recordings my mother had made before her death, a kind of quasi-confessional, which had just been leaked to the press, to coincide with release of the butler's memoir. Seven years after being hounded into hiding my mother was still being hounded, and libeled—it didn't make sense. In 1997 there'd been a nationwide reckoning, a period of collective remorse and reflection among all Britons. Everyone had agreed that the press was a pack of monsters, but consumers accepted blame as well. We all needed to do better, most people said. Now, many years later, all was forgotten. History was repeating itself daily, and I told the reporter it was "a shame."

Not a momentous declaration. But it represented the first time that either Willy or I had ever spoken publicly about Mummy. I was amazed to be the one going first. Willy always went first, in all things, and I wondered how this would go over—with him, with the world, but especially with Pa. (Not well, Marko told me later. Pa was dead-set against me addressing that topic; he didn't want either of his sons speaking about Mummy, for fear it would cause a stir, distract from his work, and perhaps shine an unflattering light on Camilla.)

Finally, with a completely false air of bravado, I shrugged and said to the reporter: *Bad news sells. Simple as that.*

Speaking of bad news…the reporter now referenced my most recent scandal.

The page-three girl, of course.

He mentioned that *some were wondering* if I'd really learned anything from my visit to the rehab clinic. Had I truly "converted"? I don't remember if he used that word, *converted,* but at least one paper had.